Collaborative Essay Practice

Group Member Names:

Discussion Facilitator: _____

Scribe: _____

Rubric & Checklist Expert: _____

Accountability & Timekeeping: _____

Prompt: How has American democracy evolved?

Step 1: Analyze the prompt. First, rewrite it in your own words:
How has the group of people who get a real voice and real rights in America changed since 1787, and what caused those changes?
Democracy = government where power comes from the people (popular sovereignty); **Evolved** = changed over time; you must show a before and an after; **American** = in the U.S., from 1787 to today

Step 2: When you are answering, think of this as a spectrum. Identify the three options you can argue:
Not a "to what extent" prompt, so the options are three ways to describe the change.

Option 1: It expanded a lot, from some white men to almost everyone

Option 2: It expanded, but slowly and unevenly, real growth, but every step was fought for (← we argue this)

Option 3: It hasn't really changed, the same groups are still held back

Step 3: Gather evidence before deciding which side to argue:

	Evidence	Which option from step 2 does this support and why?
Option 1	**Reconstruction Amendments, the "Second Founding"** 13th (1865) ended slavery, 14th (1868) citizenship, equal protection, due process, 15th (1870) no racial voting limits.	Options 1 and 2: rights reached formerly enslaved people.
Option 2	**More voters** 19th Amendment: women vote. 26th: voting age 18.	Option 1: "We the People" grew.
Option 3	**Hard amendment process** Article V: 2/3 of Congress, then 3/4 of the states. Only 27 of 11,000+ proposals passed.	Option 2: slow, but each change had wide support.
Option 4	**Judicial review** Marbury v. Madison (1803) created it. Mapp v. Ohio (1961): illegal search evidence can't be used. U.S. v. Nixon (1974): the President must follow the law.	Option 1: courts made rights real.
Option 5	**Uneven progress** 13th Amendment still allows slavery "as a punishment for crime" (documentary 13th, mass incarceration). Jim Crow blocked the 15th until the Voting Rights Act (1965).	Option 3, or the limit in Option 2.

Step 4: Draft your response, using the rubric and checklist to guide how you construct your argument

Context: The background information that shows your reader why this topic is significant by answering key questions like who, what, where, when, and why. Aim to write at least 3 connected context sentences before reaching your thesis statement.
Democracy means power comes from the people, which the Constitution calls popular sovereignty. In 1787 the Constitution allowed slavery, and mostly only white men who owned property could vote. Since then, "We the People" has come to include far more Americans.

Thesis: Clearly answer the prompt by claiming (arguing) something. Provide a clear outline of what you will discuss in your body paragraph. [Claim] because [Supporting Argument 1] and Y [Supporting Argument 2].
American democracy has evolved from a system where only some white men had a voice into a much wider democracy, because amendments extended rights to more people and judicial review made those rights real. That evolution has been slow and uneven.

Evidence 1: Remember TEA: Begin with a TOPIC SENTENCE, then introduce your EVIDENCE (facts and examples that support your argument) in the following sentences. Then through ANALYSIS, explain why the evidence matters and how it proves your thesis.
Topic: One major reason democracy has grown is the amendment process.
Evidence: The Reconstruction Amendments, the "Second Founding," changed who counts: the 13th ended slavery in 1865, the 14th gave citizenship, equal protection and due process in 1868, and the 15th banned racial limits on voting in 1870. Later, the 19th gave women the vote and the 26th lowered the voting age to 18. Each one needed 2/3 of Congress and 3/4 of the states, which is why only 27 of more than 11,000 proposals ever passed.
Analysis: This shows democracy grew on purpose and with wide support. Because the process is so hard, every amendment that passed proves the country chose to expand who counts.

Evidence 2: Remember TEA: Begin with a TOPIC SENTENCE, then introduce your EVIDENCE (facts and examples that support your argument) in the following sentences. Then through ANALYSIS, explain why the evidence matters and how it proves your thesis.
Topic: Another reason is that the courts used judicial review to make rights real.
Evidence: Marbury v. Madison (1803) gave courts the power to strike down laws. Mapp v. Ohio (1961) ruled that evidence from an illegal search can't be used, applying the 4th Amendment to the states through the 14th. U.S. v. Nixon (1974) showed that even the President must follow the law.
Analysis: Rights on paper only matter when someone enforces them. Judicial review, which isn't even written in the Constitution, became one of the main ways democracy evolved.

Alternative Perspective: Remember TEA: Begin with a TOPIC SENTENCE, then introduce your EVIDENCE (in this case, the evidence that someone arguing the other perspective would say) in the following sentences. Then through ANALYSIS, explain why the evidence matters, but why ultimately your argument is stronger than the other perspective.
Topic: Critics argue that American democracy hasn't truly evolved.
Evidence: The 13th Amendment still allows slavery "as a punishment for crime," which the documentary 13th links to mass incarceration, and Jim Crow laws blocked the 15th Amendment for almost 100 years until the Voting Rights Act of 1965.
Analysis: These show the evolution is incomplete, not absent. The same tools, amendments, courts and Congress, are what people used to fight back.

Conclusion (not on the class sheet, but the essay needs one): American democracy has grown far beyond 1787, but each step had to be fought for, and the work is still not finished.